

CD-R, CD-RW, and good software, just like its internal "brother", but that didn't do too much to boost its overall score.

All the drives except the AOpen came with USB 2.0 as well as FireWire support. The AOpen only had USB 2.0 support.

Performance

Since USB was common across all the drives, we did not test FireWire performance. The

Plextor PX-712UF obviously turned in the best burning speeds with DVDs as well as CDs. It is, after all, a faster



The Plextor PX-712UF

drive. However, the Iomega turned in better read scores.

The Iomega, though, failed the DVD+R dual-layer burning test, making it the only dual-layer drive in our entire shootout to do so.

Since the Iomega was the only dual-layer drive in this category, and it failed, we had to nullify the results of the dual-layer test to put the drives on par with each other. The AOpen drive was the slowest in reading DVD-ROMs and writing DVD+Rs, but it was faster

at DVD+RW than the Plextor PX-708UF, finishing up a minute earlier. Both of them, however, failed the CD-RW test.

Price

At Rs 11,000 for the 8X variant and Rs 13,500 for the 12X variant, the Plextor drives come out on top of the low-cost countdown. This is surprising, since Plextor products are generally not the lowest-priced—at least when other generally low-cost players such as AOpen are in the reckoning.

By the way, the underpowered AOpen is a scorching Rs 14,900 a piece, which we think is obscene for a drive with no DVD-R support and the lowest read/write speeds across all media. The Iomega was the most expensive at Rs 15,750; though, it does have dual-layer DVD+R burning.

Conclusion

From the performance point of view, and considering price-to-performance ratio, the Plextor PX-712UF comes out as winner of the Best Buy Gold award. For about Rs 1,500 extra over the PX-708A, you get a 12X DVD+R, 48X CD-R, and 24X CD-RW along with full Ultra-Speed+ compatibility. Can't beat that, can you?

The runner-up is also a Plextor—the PX-708A, thanks to its low cost and acceptable performance rating. If you



The Plextor PX-708UF

can afford to spend a few minutes more on your backups, the 8X write speed will cost you Rs 1,500 less.

EXTERNAL HARD DRIVES

An external hard drive is the peripheral of choice if there is a lot of data to be backed up, and if it needs to be accessed frequently. The faster USB 2.0 and FireWire interfaces found in most of these drives significantly reduces the time taken to back up large chunks of data.

Currently, these drives are available in three form factors. The first package is the one that houses 3.5-inch drives. These external hard drives are large, heavy, and need an external power supply. They usually ship in capacities as high as 250 GB. The other two packages house 2.5 and 1.8-inch drives respectively. These tiny drives are very light and pocketable—especially the 1.8-inch variety. They draw power from the interface.

Since these drives will be used for backup, vendors bundle along the necessary software. We gathered 14 models from five brands in our external hard drive shootout to bring you the best in the market in terms of performance and price.

The Heavyweights

There were total of five drives: one each from Freecom, Iomega, Maxtor, Seagate and Western Digital. The combined capacity of these drives was 1,040 GB, which can store around 120 to 200 DVD movies, or 1.8 lakh MP3s!

Features

Since all these drives featured 3.5-inch drives, they were bulky. The Iomega HDD 160GB was the lightest at 817 gm, and was compact. The packaging of the Freecom, which weighed 900 gm, was impressive. At 1,450 gm, the Western Digital was the heaviest. Except for the Freecom FHD-1 120GB, the rest of the drives were stackable, and

DVD Writers Scoreboard

Brand	Model	Basic Specifications—Write speeds							Score	Price (Rs)
		DVD+R	DVD-R	DVD+RW	DVD-RW	DVD+R DL	CD-R	CD-RW		
External DVD Writers										
AOpen	EHD-2412U	2.4X	NA	2.4X	NA	NA	12X	10X	41.41	14,900
IOmega	DVDRW4216E2D	12X	8X	4X	4X	2.4X	40X	24X	48.35	15,750
Plextor	PX-708UF	8X	4X	4X	2X	NA	40X	24X	58.60	11,000
Plextor	PX-712UF	12X	8X	4X	4X	NA	48X	24X	61.20	13,500
Dual-Layer DVD Writers										
ASUS	DRW-1604P	16X	16X	4X	4X	4X	32X	24X	69.90	7,250
BenQ	DW1600	16X	NA	4X	NA	2.4X	40X	24X	68.46	7,999
Lite-On	SOHW-1633S	16X	8X	4X	4X	2.4X	48X	24X	68.63	5,750
Lite-On	SOHW-832S	8X	8X	4X	4X	2.4X	40X	24X	68.20	5,550
LG	GSA-4120B	12X	8X	4X	4X	2.4X	40X	24X	59.00	8,000
MSI	DR16-B	16X	16X	4X	4X	2.4X	40X	24X	65.81	7,000
Pioneer	DVR-108	16X	16X	4X	4X	4X	32X	24X	72.77	6,300
Sony	DRU-700A	8X	8X	4X	4X	2.4X	40X	24X	62.23	7,500
Single-Layer DVD Writers										
AOpen	DRW4410R	4X	NA	4X	NA	NA	24X	10X	56.13	5,690
ASUS	DRW-0804P	8X	8X	4X	4X	NA	24X	24X	63.21	6,750
Gigabyte	GO-W0808A	8X	8X	4X	4X	NA	40X	24X	65.41	5,500
Krypton/BTC	DRW1008IM	8X	4X	4X	2X	NA	40X	24X	63.97	4,850
Lite-On	SOHW-812S	8X	8X	4X	4X	NA	40X	24X	70.47	4,495
Lite-On	SOHW-1613S	16X	8X	4X	4X	NA	48X	24X	67.96	5,595
Lite-On	SOHW-1213S	12X	8X	2.4X	4X	NA	48X	24X	69.13	4,750
Plextor	PX-708A	8X	4X	4X	2X	NA	40X	24X	65.70	5,500
Plextor	PX-712A	12X	8X	4X	4X	NA	48X	24X	70.43	7,000
Samsung	TS-H542	12X	8X	4X	4X	NA	40X	24X	61.62	6,000
Sony	DRU-540A	12X	8X	4X	4X	NA	40X	24X	62.22	7,500